

# Apple's new update For iPad

Will it finally make for a proper Mac replacement?

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For years, iPadOS has felt like an awkward middle child in Apple's ecosystem of devices, caught between the iPhone's simplicity and the Mac's productivity prowess. Despite the powerful M-series chips — the very same ones that fuel MacBooks — iPads have often felt held back by software. Even after the introduction of iPadOS as a separate operating system in 2019, the platform still feels like nothing more than a stretched version of iOS. There was power under the hood, yes, but no real reason to tap into it.

But with iPadOS 26, that's changing: dramatically. For the first time, I can see myself packing just an iPad on trips, leaving the Mac behind without anxiety. And that, frankly, is a milestone. Let's have a look at all the things that contributed to this milestone.

## Liquid Glass is the new thang

The biggest change in iPadOS 26 is Liquid Glass. Layers, semi-translucent look and curved edges that takes advantage of iPad's screen real estate.

## Liquid Glass on iPadOS 26

It's subtle, but impactful. Animations feel refined, gestures smoother, and transitions now have a fluidity that makes multitasking feel more intuitive.

## Multitasking that actually multitasks

Multitasking has long been the Achilles' heel of iPadOS. Apple tried Stage Manager in iPadOS 16 in 2022. But this year, multitasking experience has really been multiplied.



App windows can now be resized more freely, and you can place them anywhere — not just locked in tiles. It's closer than ever to the macOS windowing system, yet adapted for touch.

## The humble menu bar gets its iPad moment

One of the most Mac-like changes the iPadOS 26 got is the global menu bar for Apps. Previously, App settings used to be hidden behind touch-only gestures or floating menus.

Now, a persistent menu bar sits at the top — context-aware and adaptive to the app in use. It's subtle, but for power users like me, it's a game changer. It brings back familiarity and precision, especially when paired with a trackpad or keyboard. It doesn't feel like you're fighting the OS to do things.

## Finder? Close enough.

The Files app on iPadOS finally got the attention it deserves. The new update brings proper column view, better sorting, and tabbed browsing — just like Finder on macOS. External drive support is more robust, file transfers are snappier, and most importantly, the UI finally respects the needs of users who deal with large sets of documents or media.

## Mac's quietest hero lands on iPad

Preview has arrived. The simple, reliable, underappreciated app from macOS is now on iPad. You can now view PDFs, images, and documents without third-party workarounds. There are also markup tools built-in, and integration with the Apple Pencil feels native, not like an afterthought.

## When will iPadOS 26 come out?

iPadOS 26 is currently available as a developer beta, with a public beta expected in July. The final stable release will arrive in September 2025, alongside the new iPads and iPhones, following Apple's usual fall schedule.

## Final thoughts

This is a software correction. Apple has embraced the iPad's potential. iPadOS 26 doesn't just make it more like a Mac; it makes it make sense. **d**